Political Discontent and Regime Instability

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Data Availability Statement

Replication data is available on the Harvard Dataverse [link tbd], and the work's complete revision history is available at https://github.com/fsolt/trust_stability.

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abstract

Introduction

Literature Review

Theory

Data and Measurement

While measures tapping political discontent abound in existing studies, no single measure of political discontent has won universal acceptance in the discipline. The lack of the universal measure can be partly attributed to the fact that scholars have defined political discontent in various ways. For example, some scholars, notably Easton, conceptualize political discontent as a lack of diffuse support for the political system, while others define it as low external efficacy, perceived democratic deficits, political distrust or dissatisfaction with incumbent leaders (Easton 1975; Jennings, Stoker, and Twyman 2016; Muller and Jukam 1983; Norris 2011). Different definitions of discontent have fragmented its measures, and each resulting measure has limited coverage across countries and over time. The fragmentation is such that scholars still debate whether political discontent is even rising worldwide (Jennings et al. 2017).

Following Easton (1975), we define political discontent as a lack of diffuse support for the political system. Diffuse support concerns perceptions of system legitimacy and

serves as a 'reservoir of favorable attitudes or goodwill' toward a system. What distinguish diffuse support from specific support is its more enduring character and its consequences beyond any single government. As its name implies, specific support concerns support for the specific incumbent government, its leaders or its policies. It often fluctuates without a systematic pattern, and researchers have argued that it does not necessarily translate into rejection of the regime itself (Miller 1974; Citrin 1974; Craig and Maggiotto 1981) - not only because of its fluctuation but also because, in democracy, elections allow citizens to express dissatisfaction and replace leaders they are dissatisfied with (Muller and Jukam 1983). The erosion of diffuse support, by contrast, reflects systematically lower support for the basic political arrangements and can thus increase public willingness to seek radical change to the political regime (Jennings et al. 2017). As this paper examines how political discontent affects regime stability, the concept of diffuse support is better suited to our theoretical focus.

We rely on Public Political Discontent (PPD), a set of latent country-year estimates of political discontent generated by the Dynamic Comparative Public Opinion (DCPO) model (2026). The DCPO model is a Bayesian hierarchical item response theory model that estimates latent public opinion constructs of interest from multiple cross-national survey datasets (Solt 2020). The latent variable model approach to public opinion estimation was introduced to the field as a means of addressing the fragmentation of public opinion data across time, countries, and disparate survey items, and its applications have now extended to public support for democracy, policy ideology, and preference for redistribution (Berwick and Caughey 2025; Claassen 2020; Caughey, O'Grady, and Warshaw 2019). These models estimate the latent concept by gleaning information from multiple survey items while accounting for differences across surveys through parameters for question difficulty and dispersion, adjusting for country-specific item bias, incorporating responses from both dichotomous and ordinal questions, and smoothing estimates in years with sparse data while preserving cross-national comparability through dynamic priors. Drawing on the DCPO method, the PPD dataset assembles 388 survey datasets containing 111 distinct survey items tapping political discontent, covering 136 different countries over the 56 years from 1968 to 2023.

We use the PPD for three reasons. First, the dataset conceptualizes political discontent as a lack of diffuse support, aligning directly with our theoretical focus. Second, it

provides, to our knowledge, the most comprehensive country-year estimates of political discontent, which offers an important methodological benefit: our results do not depend on the choice of any particular cross-national survey dataset (Claassen 2020). Third, the PPD estimates show strong validation results, including internal and external convergent validity and construct validity (Adcock and Collier 2001).

The choice of dependent variable deserves equal attention. As implied by the term itself, any measure of regime stability depends on how a political regime is defined, and the literature offers several distinct traditions (Cianetti, Del Panta, and Owen 2025). The procedural approach, which is the most common approach identified in Cianetti et al's(2025) review of regime studies, defines political regimes as the set of formal or informal rules governing how political power is acquired and exercised (Bjørnskov and Rode 2020; Boix, Miller, and Rosato 2013; Munck 1996; Schmitter and Karl 1991; Cianetti, Del Panta, and Owen 2025). This approach generally produces distinctions between democracy or non-democracy or autocracy, although the specific institutional criteria used to distinguish regime types vary across measures such as Polity, V-Dem and Freedom House.

Another influential tradition adopts actor-centered definition of political regimes, focusing instead on the composition of ruling coalition (Cianetti, Del Panta, and Owen 2025). Scholars in this tradition argue that similar formal institution can coexist with substantially different ruling coalitions, with important consequences for the behavior of political leaders and for whose interests are represented by politics (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014). From this definition, procedural measures may overlook politically consequential changes in ruling coalitions that occur without a corresponding change in formal institutional rules, or may misclassify institutional changes, either improving or worsening the quality of democracy, by the same autucrat as regime change. (Wright and Bak 2016). For example, the Polity score fail to identify regime collapse such as the 1958 coup in Iraq when the regimes before and after the coup receive similar Polity scores and misclassify institutional liberalization in Gabon from 1991 to 1992 as regime change.

Beyond disagreement over what constitutes a regime, scholars also disagree over what constitutes regime change (Maerz et al. 2024). Maerz et al.(2024) distinguish between two dominant approaches. The transitologist approach focuses on transitions between regime categories and typically treats democratic transition and democratic breakdown as discrete events. The incrementalist approach, by contrast, conceptualizes democracy

and autocracy as points along a continuum and examines gradual changes in the level of democracy. Further,they identify three major limitations of these approaches. First, each relies on restrictive assumptions about the comparability of observations. The transitologist approach assumes unit homogeneity by treating observations within the same regime category as comparable, while the incrementalist approach avoids this assumption but instead assumes constant and symmetric effects of factors for both improving or decreasing quality of democracy. Second, both approaches tend to operationalize regime change through annual observations, potentially amplifying short-term fluctuations even though regime transformation often unfolds gradually over multiple years. Third, the two approaches have difficulty incorporating democratization and autocratization within a common framework. Transitologist studies generally treat democratic transition and democratic breakdown as separate processes, whereas incrementalist studies often treat equivalent movements toward and away from democracy as empirically comparable changes. Maerz et al. therefore conceptualize regime change as a sustained and substantial process that may or may not ultimately result in a discrete regime transition.

In this paper, we adopt a procedural conception of political regimes. Because this is the dominant approach in the existing empirical literature, doing so allows our findings to engage directly with a broad literature on democratization, autocratization, and regime stability. At the same time, to address the limitations of both the transitologist and incrementalist approaches, we rely on the Episodes of Regime Transformation (ERT) dataset (Maerz et al. 2024). Rather than identifying regime change solely from discrete transitions or annual changes in democracy scores, the ERT dataset identifies sustained episodes of substantial change along the democracy–autocracy continuum. Using these data, we first examine whether higher levels of political discontent are associated with the onset of regime-transformation episodes. However, rather than assuming that the effect of political discontent on regime stability is the same across regime types, we allow its effect to vary between democracies and autocracies(Claassen 2020; Tai, Hu, and Solt 2024). Specifically, we use the regime-type classification provided by the ERT dataset to construct two regime-specific measures of political discontent: political discontent in democracies and political discontent in autocracies. Each measure varies with the underlying level of political discontent only when a country belongs to the corresponding

regime type and is coded zero otherwise. We include both measures, together with the regime-type indicator, in the same model, to estimate separately the association between political discontent and the onset of regime transformation in democracies and autocracies. We further distinguish the direction of these episodes and examine whether political discontent is associated with the onset of episode resulting in specific outcomes, such as democratization or autocratization. This approach can examine whether political discontent contributes to the initiation of regime transformation while avoiding the assumption that all transformations lead to the same outcome.

To examine these relationships, we employ discrete-time logistic regression, which models how covariates affect the probability that an episode begins within discrete time intervals. This approach is appropriate because our dependent variable, the onset of episode, is measured in country-years. We consequently do not employ continuous-time hazard models such as the Cox proportional hazards model. For each specification, we estimate both conventional logistic regression using a generalized linear model (GLM) and Firth's penalized-likelihood logistic regression (Puhr et al. 2017; Muchlinski et al. 2016). The latter provides a robustness check against small-sample bias and separation that may arise when regime-transformation onsets are relatively rare events.

To account for measurement uncertainty in political discontent, we use the method of composition (MOC). The MOC repeatedly draws 900 simulated values of political discontent from its estimated distribution, re-estimates each model using each draw, and combines the resulting estimates into a final distribution of coefficients (Tai, Hu, and Solt 2024). This procedure propagates uncertainty from the measurement of political discontent into the uncertainty surrounding our regression estimates. The models also include a standard set of covariates associated with regime transformation: logged GDP per capita, GDP growth, regional democracy, the percentage of the population that is Muslim, resource dependence, OECD membership, income inequality measured using SWIID 9.8, and logged population. We additionally account for temporal dependence by including the regime-age clock, its squared term, and a count of previous transitions. We also include public support for democracy as a control (Claassen 2020; Choi 2026).

Results

Figure 1 presents the estimated association between political discontent and the onset of regime-transformation episodes separately for democracies and autocracies. The results reveal a clear difference across regime types. In autocracies, higher political discontent is positively and significantly associated with the onset of regime transformation episode. A one-standard-deviation increase in political discontent is associated with an average increase of 5.0 percentage points in the probability of episode onset (95% credible interval: 1.0 to 9.9), net of the other variables included in the model. This substantive association is particularly notable because it represents the largest estimated change in the probability of episode onset among the variables included in the model. By contrast, political discontent is not significantly associated with episode onset in democracies, although its point estimate is also positive.

Taken together, these results are consistent with the expectation that political discontent is associated with greater regime instability, but suggest that this relationship is concentrated in autocratic regimes. One possible explanation for this regime-specific pattern is that democratic elections provide an institutional mechanism through which political discontent can be channeled without necessarily threatening the regime itself (Ma et al. 2026). In democracies, dissatisfied citizens can replace incumbent leaders through elections rather than translating dissatisfaction with political authorities into rejection of the political regime (Muller and Jukam 1983; Rooduijn, Van Der Brug, and De Lange 2016). Autocracies generally provide fewer institutionalized opportunities for such electoral replacement, making accumulated political discontent more likely to coincide with broader pressures for regime transformation.

Public support for democracy exhibits a different regime-specific pattern. In autocracies, democratic support is not significantly associated with the onset of regime-transformation episodes. In democracies, however, higher support for democracy is negatively and significantly associated with episode onset. A one-standard-deviation increase in support is associated with an average reduction of 1.4 percentage points in the probability of episode onset (95% credible interval: 0.4 to 2.2). It should not, however, be interpreted as direct evidence that democratic support reduces the probability of democratic breakdown. The dependent variable captures the onset of substantial and sustained transformation in either direction along the democracy–autocracy continuum. Among

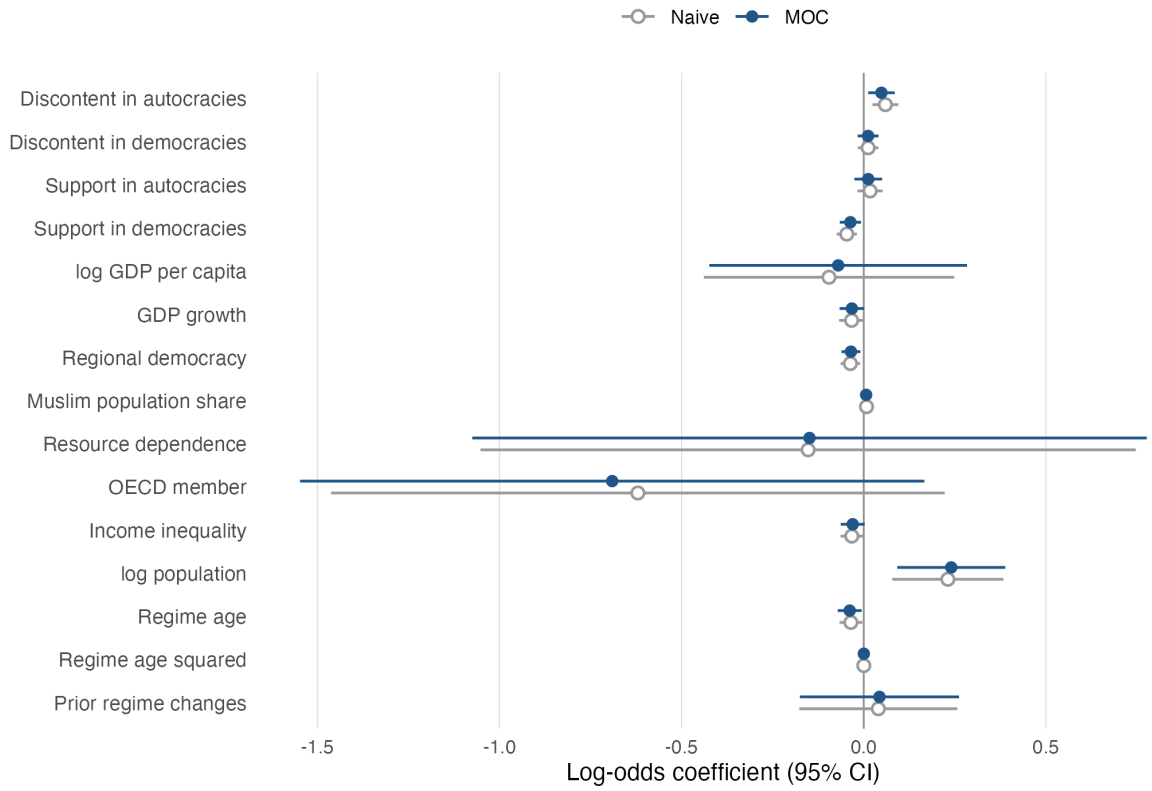


Figure 1: Coefficients from the discrete-time hazard model of episode onset.

democracies, therefore, a lower probability of episode onset could reflect a lower likelihood of democratic regression, democratic deepening, or both. We examine the direction and eventual outcomes of these transformation episodes separately below. Among the control variables, regional democracy and regime age are negatively associated with episode onset, whereas population size is positively associated with it. GDP growth also shows a negative, although only marginally significant, association with episode onset, consistent with previous evidence linking stronger economic performance to greater regime stability (Gassebner, Lamla, and Vreeland 2013). The remaining covariates are not statistically distinguishable from zero at conventional levels after accounting for measurement uncertainty.

Figure 2 further examines whether the destabilizing association of political discontent in autocracies takes a particular direction—upward (democratization episodes) or downward (autocratization episodes) along the democracy–autocracy continuum. It should be noted that democratization and autocratization here do not necessarily denote transitions across regime types. Instead, they represent sustained movement up or down the continuum, following Maerz et al.(2024). The upper panel distinguishes between these two

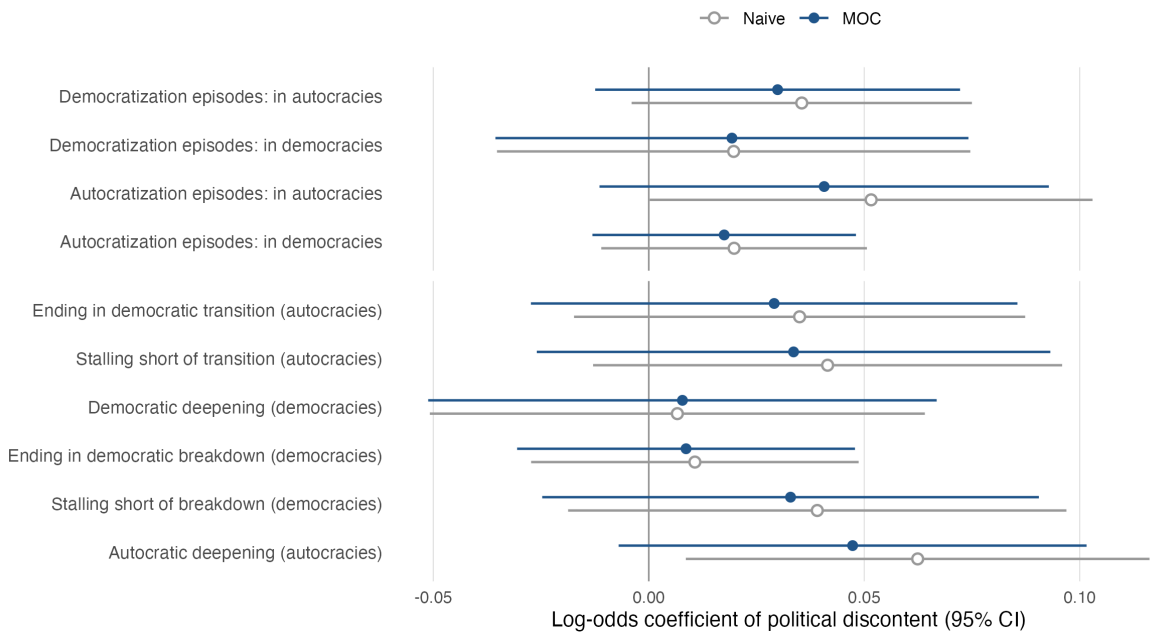


Figure 2: Coefficients from discrete-time hazard models of direction-specific and outcome-specific episode onset.

directions. In autocracies, the estimated association of political discontent is positive for the onset of both democratization episodes (95% credible interval: -0.012 to 0.074) and autocratization episodes (95% credible interval: -0.012 to 0.093), but neither estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero after accounting for measurement uncertainty. A similar absence of significant associations appears among democracies. These results suggest that, although political discontent increases the overall likelihood that an autocratic regime enters a period of transformation, it does not systematically push that transformation in either a democratic or an autocratic direction.

The lower panel examines this possibility more closely by distinguishing the eventual outcomes of transformation episodes, drawing on the ERT dataset's outcome classifications. Consistent with the results above, political discontent is not significantly associated with whether liberalization in an autocracy ultimately produces a democratic transition or stalls short of one; nor does it significantly predict democratic deepening, democratic breakdown, or episodes that stall short of breakdown among democracies. The largest outcome-specific estimate appears for autocratic deepening (95% credible interval: -0.003 to 0.104). Notably, both this association and the association with autocratization-episode onset in autocracies are statistically significant in the naïve estimates, which do not account for measurement uncertainty in political discontent ($p = 0.023$ and $p = 0.049$,

respectively). However, both lose statistical significance once this measurement uncertainty is incorporated. Taken together, these findings indicate that political discontent operates primarily as a destabilizing force in autocratic regimes: it is associated with whether an autocracy enters a sustained period of regime transformation, but not with the direction that transformation takes or the outcome it ultimately produces. Political discontent therefore predicts the initiation of regime instability more clearly than its political destination.

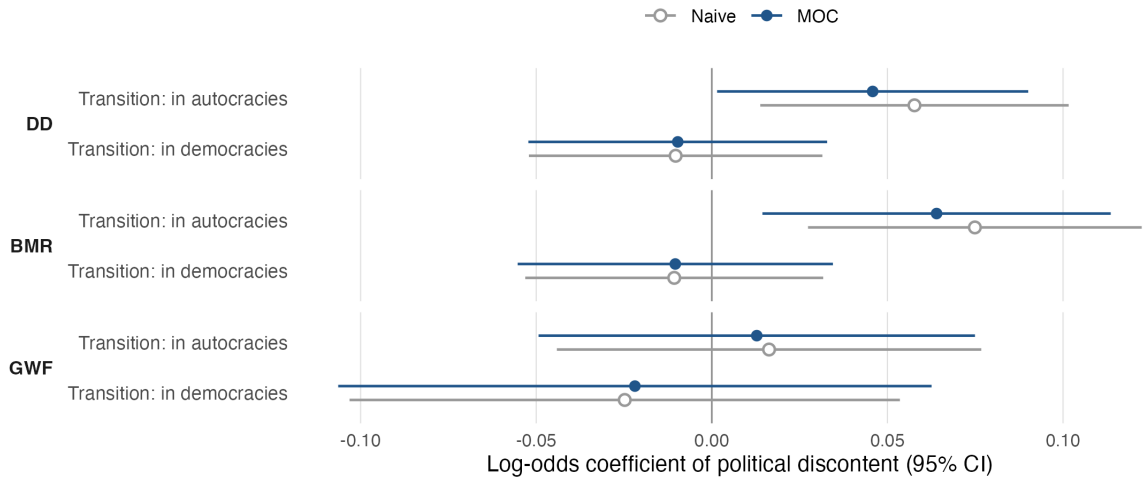


Figure 3: Coefficients from discrete-time hazard models of completed regime transitions under canonical regime codings.

To assess whether our conclusions depend on the ERT coding of regime transformation, we re-estimate the transition models using three widely used dichotomous regime classifications: the DD classification of Cheibub, Gandhi, and Vreeland, as updated by Bjørnskov and Rode (2020), the Boix–Miller–Rosato (BMR) measure (Boix, Miller, and Rosato 2013), and the Geddes–Wright–Frantz (GWF) classification (Geddes, Wright, and Frantz 2014). The results are presented in Figure 3. Under both DD and BMR, political discontent in autocracies is positively associated with a transition to democracy (DD: 95% credible interval: 0.003 to 0.091; BMR: 95% credible interval: 0.019 to 0.114). By contrast, political discontent is not associated with regime transitions originating in democracies under either coding. The GWF estimates follow a similar directional pattern, with a positive association in autocracies and a negative association in democracies, but neither estimate is statistically distinguishable from zero. We argue that this null effect results from GWF's shorter temporal coverage, which ends in 2010, leaving considerably fewer transition events.

Table 1: Event Correspondence across Regime-Transition Codings.

Event	Coding	Events	Captured by ERT	Captured by DD	Captured by BMR	Captured by GWF
Democratization	ERT	46	–	5/46 (11%)	5/46 (11%)	3/33 (9%)
Democratization	DD	25	5/25 (20%)	–	6/24 (25%)	6/13 (46%)
Democratization	BMR	18	5/18 (28%)	6/18 (33%)	–	3/12 (25%)
Democratization	GWF	8	3/8 (38%)	6/8 (75%)	3/8 (38%)	–
Breakdown	ERT	17	–	6/17 (35%)	6/17 (35%)	2/9 (22%)
Breakdown	DD	22	7/22 (32%)	–	10/22 (45%)	4/8 (50%)
Breakdown	BMR	18	6/18 (33%)	10/18 (56%)	–	4/9 (44%)
Breakdown	GWF	6	3/6 (50%)	4/6 (67%)	4/6 (67%)	–

At first glance, the DD and BMR findings appear somewhat inconsistent with the ERT results reported above. Under the ERT framework, political discontent predicts the onset of transformation episodes in autocracies but not whether those episodes ultimately result in a democratic transition. Under DD and BMR, by contrast, political discontent is associated with transitions from autocracy to democracy. An event-level comparison, however, shows that these codings identify substantially different sets of completed regime changes, as shown in Table 1. Among the 46 ERT democratization episodes ending in democratic transition, only 5 (11%) contain a democratization event identified by DD, and the same number contain one identified by BMR. Conversely, only 20% of DD democratizations and 28% of BMR democratizations occur within an ERT episode that ultimately ends in democratic transition. The correspondence is somewhat greater for democratic breakdown: DD and BMR each identify transitions within 35% of ERT breakdown-ending episodes, while approximately one-third of the breakdowns identified by each dichotomous measure occur within the corresponding ERT episodes. Even DD and BMR themselves identify substantially different sets of transition events, indicating that disagreement over completed regime transitions is not unique to the ERT framework.

Taken together, these results reinforce our broader conclusion that political discontent is associated with regime instability in autocracies, while providing less consistent evidence about the political destination of that instability. The ERT framework shows most clearly that political discontent increases the likelihood that an autocracy enters a sustained process of regime transformation, without systematically predicting its direction or eventual outcome. The DD and BMR results indicate that some of this instability is classified as completed democratization under alternative regime definitions. However, the limited correspondence between these democratization events and ERT transition episodes, as well as between DD and BMR themselves, suggests that this conclusion is

sensitive to how regime change is conceptualized and coded. Thus, we argue that political discontent is more consistently associated with the destabilization of autocratic regimes than with whether that destabilization ultimately culminates in democracy.

Summary and Discussion

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Online Supplementary Materials

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